

Weblogs, whether they're for business or pleasure share two basic components: Regularly updated content about the main topic of the weblog and a list of links to the site's regular community members - usually along the side of the screen. This encourages discussion and idea-sharing, which is one of the stickier reasons to keep coming back. The adoption rate of weblogs continues to go up commensurately with additional, anyone-can-do-this applications. Primalrecords.com, an online music retailer, has a fully transactional weblog that functions as smoothly as a conventionally developed web site. Of course, the all-telling clue that weblogs are really coming into their own as accepted business media is how many now carry advertising.

Business Blog Strategies - Early Adopters

As with any new technology, the more progressive companies are the early adopters. They have the vision to look beyond the initial rudimentary application and appreciate a self-publishing tool that will significantly change how we communicate and collaborate. For example, every organization has vast stores of intellectual capital idling away in the minds of its leaders and top managers. But the ability to share it has been limited by conventional forms of communication: Meetings, reports and presentations. Email certainly opened up the lines to two-way discourse, but unlike weblogs, the exchange does not build on itself. Moreover, it's generally one-at-one communication, often with no expectation of dialogue beyond a single reply. Web sites, and extranets in particular, have the technology for targeted community building but they're clunky dialogue tools, requiring HTML programmers to cut and post all the content and a certain amount of hosting support.

Now companies are encouraging staff members to self-publish professional weblogs, thereby doing an end run around the walls that have prevented free range business discussion on the Web. No battling for representation on the company site. No request forms for content changes and updates. Equally important, the weblog's self-publishing technology automatically democratizes the use of the web. Typically, one department is responsible for managing